g) The Moghūls attack Babur

On his second return to Ḥiṣār, Babur faced significant danger when a sudden attack was launched by the Moghūls on his camp outside the town, where he lay at night. Firishta mentions that Babur had reproached them for their misconduct, but the lack of specific details connecting this incident with the earlier defeat suggests that their wrongdoings may have been part of the oppressive rule over the local population, later punished by ‘Ubaidu’l-lāh Khān.

Awakened from his sleep by the commotion caused by his guards’ resistance to the Moghūl attack, Babur managed to escape with great difficulty and without a single attendant, seeking refuge within the fort.[11] The conspirators looted his camp and then retreated to Qarā-tīgīn. Babur was in no position to confront them, so he left a few men in Ḥiṣār and went to Mīrzā Khān in Qūndūz.

In Babur’s absence, Ḥiṣār endured a devastating famine, an extraordinary snowfall, and the depredations of the Moghūls. ‘Ubaid Khān took revenge on behalf of Babur against the horde. Upon learning of their excesses, he encamped outside their position in Wakhsh, which was defended by rivers, hills, and snow. He waited until a path had thawed, then attacked them, avenging the year of misery they had inflicted on the Ḥiṣārīs. Ḥaidar notes that it was the treacherous actions of these Moghūls that led to the loss of Ḥiṣār for Bābur and its recovery for the Aūzbeg.[12]

These Moghūls were led by individuals who, when Sa’īd went to Andijān, chose to remain with Babur. One of the three mentioned by Ḥaidar was Ayūb Begchīk. He later regretted his disloyalty and, while lying on his deathbed some two years later (AD 1514) in Yāngī-ḥiṣār, confessed to Sa’īd Khān that his faithlessness to Babur in Ḥiṣār and the oath he had broken at the instigation of the Moghūl chiefs were causing him unbearable remorse.[*]

During this year, but before the Moghūl treachery against Babur, Ḥaidar left him and began his journey to Sa’id in Andijān, marking the start of his nineteen years of service.

9 March of AD 1513 to 26 February of AD 1514

During this year, Babur might have spent some time in Khishm.[†] For two or three months of that period, he had one of the Shāh’s retainers in his service, Khwāja Kamālu’d-dīn Maḥmūd. Khwāja Kamālu’d-dīn had fled from Ghaj-davān to Balkh, where he learned that the people of Balkh were favouring an Aūzbeg chief whose arrival was imminent. Therefore, he decided to join Babur. In Jumāda II (August of AD 1513), upon hearing that the Aūzbeg sulṭān had left Balkh, Khwāja Kamālu’d-